

Get Ready to Scratch

A 10-minute check to do before the first session. It makes sure your device can run Scratch, so on night one we start making things move instead of troubleshooting Wi-Fi. No coding or "tech" experience needed. If you can open a website, you can do this.



~10 min

No coding experience required

Laptop or Chromebook + a mouse

PLEASE TRY THIS BEFORE SESSION 1

You can't break anything, and there's nothing to buy. If a step doesn't work, that's fine: jot down where you got stuck and arrive five minutes early. We'll sort it out together before we begin.

WHAT TO BRING

- ◆ **A laptop or Chromebook** (Windows, macOS, ChromeOS, or Linux). A tablet will work, but dragging blocks with a fingertip is fiddlier. If a tablet is all you have, bring it and tell us.
- ◆ **A mouse**, and this one matters. Scratch is all drag-and-drop, and most grown-ups find a trackpad frustrating for it. Any cheap USB or wireless mouse will do. *Strongly recommended.*
- ◆ Your **charger**. A session runs two hours.
- ◆ **Reading glasses** if you use them. Blocks have small text, and you'll also learn to zoom the code area.
- ◆ An **email address** you can check during class (only if you choose to make an account; see Step 2).

1 Open Scratch and meet the cat

~2 min

- 1 Open a **current web browser**: Chrome, Edge, Firefox, or Safari. If it asks to update, let it.
- 2 Go to **scratch.mit.edu**.
- 3 Click **Create** at the top left of the page.
- 4 The Scratch editor opens with an orange **cat** on a white stage. That's the Scratch Cat, and seeing it means Scratch works on your device.

WHAT IS IT?

Scratch is a free coding playground made at MIT for kids aged roughly 8–16. Instead of typing code, you snap colorful blocks together like LEGO. It runs in your web browser, so there's nothing to install.

2 Make a free account (optional)

~4 min

- 1 On scratch.mit.edu, click **Join Scratch** and follow the steps: username, password, birth month/year, and an email address.
- 2 Scratch sends a **confirmation email**. Open it and click the link, or you won't be able to share projects later. (Check your spam folder if it doesn't arrive.)
- 3 Write your username and password somewhere you'll find them on Session 1.

WHY BOTHER?

An account lets Scratch save your projects online, so you can pick them up at home. Without one you can still do everything in class: you save to your computer with **File → Save to your computer**, which we'll practise on night one.

THIS ONE IS FOR YOU, NOT YOUR CHILD

Don't make your child's account yet. In the course you'll set one up **at home, together**, using **your** email as the parent/guardian address, with a username that doesn't reveal their real name. We walk through it step by step.

3 Know the offline backup

~1 min

- 1 If Scratch **didn't open** in Step 1 (for example, a work laptop or school network blocks it), or you have no internet at home, there's a free **Scratch app** that runs without the internet.
- 2 Get it from scratch.mit.edu/download. It's available for Windows, macOS, ChromeOS, and Android tablets.
- 3 Install it only if you need it. The browser version is all most people use.

SAME SCRATCH, SAVED DIFFERENTLY

The offline app has the same blocks and editor. The difference is that projects save as files on your computer (`.sb3`), not to an online account.

4

Confirm it works: move the cat

~3 min

- 1 In the editor, the **blue Motion blocks** are on the left. Find **move (10) steps**.
- 2 **Drag** it into the big empty area in the middle (the code area) and let go.
- 3 **Click the block** once. The cat should scoot a little to the right. Click again and it moves again.

A blue Scratch 'move 10 steps' block with the number '10' in a white circle.

✓ YOU'RE READY

If the cat moved, you're set for Session 1. You've just run your first program, and you're done with setup. If it didn't, note which step stopped you and we'll fix it in the first few minutes of class.

FREQUENTLY ASKED

◆ DO I NEED TO BE GOOD WITH COMPUTERS?

No. If you can open a website and click a link, you're ready. We start from zero, go slowly, and nothing you do in Scratch can harm your computer.

◆ CAN MY CHILD COME TO THE SESSIONS?

Sessions 1–4 and most of Session 6 are for grown-ups only. You learn first, then practise teaching. Children join us for **Session 5, Family Build Night**, where you build a game together with your child in charge, and for the **showcase and graduation** at the end of Session 6. We'll send details in Session 4.

◆ IS SCRATCH REALLY FREE? IS IT SAFE FOR KIDS?

Yes, it's free, with no ads or in-app purchases. Scratch is run by the non-profit Scratch Foundation and its online community is moderated. The course spends a whole lesson on safe accounts, sharing, and family rules so you can decide what's right for your child.

◆ WILL MY HOME COMPUTER OR TABLET WORK?

Almost certainly. If Step 1 worked on it, it's fine. Bring questions about specific home devices to the break and we'll help.

◆ WHAT IF I CAN'T FINISH THE SETUP?

Come anyway. We'll have a spare mouse or two and time at the start to get everyone to the cat.

